a chore in itself. But such a scenario could impact one's wellbeing and productivity at work. "During Covid, when we were left without a house help for some months and with an infant at home, it was a tough time," states Rama. Her daughter-in-law was recouping after giving birth to a girl, her younger son was awaiting results to know where he would go for his master's. Moreover, the fear of Covid in a household with vulnerable senior citizens took its toll on her. "Some days I just couldn't focus on work despite sitting in online meetings," she recounts.

Managing a household with financial constraints and emotional commitment could have a negative impact on all aspects of your life. It could also put a strain on your relationship with your children, spouse and the quality of care you are giving your aging parents. "When Uday was unwell due to Covid, I just couldn't manage my in-laws who felt they were jailed at home when it was the case for everyone. My parents had just moved to an apartment near mine and were yet to familiarise themselves with the markets around," says Rashi.

In order to achieve a certain balance between work and caregiving responsibilities, you should consider discussing the situation—financial and emotional—with all the members (see *Coping with Financial Stress*). There are alternatives such as outsourcing chores at home, which could leave you with time. You could also consider asking your siblings to chip in so that you aren't the one who is completely burdened. "I could feel the stress that Rama was going through and decided to take leave for a month once the Covid situation improved," says Seshadri. As he was able to spend more time with his parents and his mother-in-law, Rama felt less guilty and it helped her in her work.

It is very easy to get caught up in your caregiving duties and put your family's needs above your own. Striking a balance is near-impossible—financially and emotionally. You could face burnout or lack of fulfilment when putting personal plans on hold and not making enough time for yourself. It is a good idea to talk about the financial situation at home with both elderly parents and young children even when you aren't facing any financial crunch. Likewise, sharing tasks, however small, at home or responsibilities in managing finances will make everyone mentally and emotionally recharged and provide a fresh perspective on how to manage the situation among your loved ones.



AVOID DIPPING INTO YOUR RETIREMENT SAVINGS, LENDING OR BORROWING MONEY WITHOUT A CLEAR UNDERSTANDING OF THE IMPACT OF SUCH A MOVE

It is tough to school your parents as they grow old and depend on you for emotional and sometimes financial support. Do not postpone financial or other routine tasks for a later date, because time is of the essence. "I was postponing our house purchase, but finally when I did, the feeling of owning something was nice," says Sathish. As he discusses his work and financial situation with his wife and older brother, he finds their support comforting to tide over tough situations.

It is a good idea to communicate clearly with all members of the house and also set inter-generational boundaries with what you are and are not willing to do to help your children and parents. Often when in-laws and older children live with you, the authority structure in the household could be confusing for other people working in the house. It is important that some ground rules are set and adhered to.

As longevity increases, the idea of a Sandwich Generation evolves and there are many combinations in which it exists. The one constant in all of this is the need for the generation in the middle to look after its own needs first before helping those above and below it. This priority would depend on several factors, for you to be able to help your parents out with confidence and grace, and for your kids to achieve their potential. ■